
HS 509: Weimar Republic and Nazi Germany

Course Code	HS 509
Course Name	Weimar Republic and Nazi Germany
L-T-P-C	3-0-0-3
Prerequisites	None
Intended for	Ph.D./Masters/B.Tech. (3rd and 4th year)
Mutual Exclusion	None
Approval	12th Senate (Mar 2017), in the M.Tech Power Electronics and Drives curriculum; 62nd BoA (Jan 2026)

Preamble

The Weimar Republic, with its liberal constitution, parliament elected by universal suffrage, civil rights and rule of law, was Germany's first attempt at democracy. This course examines the turbulent events, from its birth in the aftermath of defeat in the Great War to the destruction of the Republic, in their political-social-economic setting that led to the rise and consolidation of the Nazi party during the inter-war years. The Republic witnessed both a remarkable cultural renaissance and deep political instability. The collapse of the Republic paved the way for the National Socialist regime which transformed the cultural and technological innovation into instruments of propaganda, violence and genocide.

Motivation

This course offers an interdisciplinary understanding of modern German and European history by focusing on the Weimar Republic and the Nazi regime and helps students trace the transformation from a democratic experiment to an authoritarian state. By contrasting the cultural innovation in architecture, cinema and art of the Weimar Period with the Nazi regime's appropriation of the same forms for propaganda and ideological control, the course examines not only the political developments but also the cultural and social tools that shaped Germany in the first half of the twentieth century.

The course will fit into the Minor in German Studies and offers essential historical and cultural background for students who wish to take the course *Post-war Germany: Politics, Society and Culture*. The period covered here establishes the foundation for understanding how Germany rebuilt itself after 1945, how it confronted questions of guilt and memory, and how it became the modern state and society which is studied in the post-war course.

Course Outcomes

On completion of this course, students will be able to:

1. Develop a comprehensive understanding of the major political, social, and economic transformations in Germany between 1919 and 1945.
2. Critically evaluate the structural weaknesses of the Weimar Republic and identify the contributing factors that facilitated the rise of National Socialism.
3. Study how art, cinema, and literature reflected and responded to the tensions of modernity and the rise of political extremism.
4. Analyze the ideological uses of art and propaganda under Nazism.
5. Examine the ethical dimensions of technological advancements, propaganda, and the application of scientific principles within totalitarian regimes.

Course Modules

- **Module 1: From Empire to Republic:** This module offers the students an overview of the events that led to the proclamation of the Weimar Republic, briefly outlining topics like the unification of Germany and the formation of the German Empire under Bismarck, the First World War, the collapse of Imperial Germany, among others. (2 Hours)
- **Module 2: Weimar Democracy and its Challenges (1919-1923):** (4 Hours) Topics:
 - Treaty of Versailles (1919)
 - Weimar Constitution: Liberalism and its contradictions
 - Political fragmentation and hyperinflation (1921-1923)
 - Kapp Putsch and the Ruhr Crisis
 - Early cultural and political polarization
- **Module 3: The Golden Twenties – Culture, Modernity and the New Woman (1924-1929):** (5 Hours) Topics:
 - Economic stabilization: The Dawes Plan and Stresemann's diplomacy
 - Cultural flourishing: The Bauhaus movement, cinema, and intellectual life
 - Expressionism (*Die Brücke*, *Der Blaue Reiter*; painters like Kirchner, Klee, Marc)
 - Rise of photography and photojournalism (August Sander).
 - Cinema and modernity: *Metropolis*, *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari*, *M*, *The Blue Angel*
 - *The Neue Frau*: changing gender roles, visibility, and emancipation
 - Readings: short prose or poems by Erich Kästner, Kurt Tucholsky, excerpts from Thomas Mann or Bertolt Brecht, and selected works by Käthe Kollwitz.
- **Module 4: The Great Depression and the Crisis of Democracy (1929-1932):** (4 Hours) Topics:
 - The Great Depression and the collapse of the Weimar economy
 - Unemployment, hunger and radicalization
 - Polarisation of German politics. Rise of the NSDAP and the Communist Party, KPD
 - Failure of Weimar institutions, collapse of the democratic system and the increasing use of presidential decrees
 - The myth of betrayal (*Dolchstoßlegende*) and national humiliation
- **Module 5: The Road to Power (1930-1933):** (3 Hours) Topics:
 - Nazi propaganda and mobilization
 - The 1932 elections and appointment of Hitler as Chancellor
 - The Reichstag Fire and Enabling Act
 - Weakness of conservative elites and democratic institutions
- **Module 6: Building the Nazi State (1933-1934):** (3 Hours) Topics:
 - Night of the Long Knives (1934)
 - Removal of political rivals, Jews and other minorities
 - Hitler's assumption of the role of Führer. *Führerprinzip*
 - Internal Nazi power struggles. Purge of SA leaders
 - Role of the SS and Gestapo in Nazi rule
- **Module 7: Ideology, Race, and the "Volksgemeinschaft" (1933–1939):** (3 Hours) Topics:
 - Racial policies and the Nuremberg Laws
 - Anti-Semitism and exclusionary nationalism
 - The Nazi economy: autarky, rearmament, and labor mobilization
 - The "colonial imagination" and racial hierarchies within Europe and Africa
- **Module 8: Culture and Society in Nazi Germany:** (2 Hours) Topics:
 - Propaganda as culture: film, media, and the cult of Hitler
 - Gleichschaltung of cultural institutions
 - Roles of arts, media, and education in promoting Nazi ideology
 - Nazi Youth Culture (Hitler Youth and Bund Deutscher Mädel)
- **Module 9: Gender, Family, and the Reversal of Modernity:** (3 Hours) Topics:
 - Nazi gender ideology and the dismantling of the New Woman
 - Women's roles: *Kinder*, *Küche*, *Kirche* (children, kitchen, church)
 - Erasure of feminist and queer spaces of the Weimar era

- The continuity of patriarchal nationalism
- **Module 10: Expansion and War (1936–1941):** (4 Hours) Topics:
 - Remilitarization of the Rhineland, Anschluss, Munich Agreement
 - Lebensraum and colonial continuities
 - The Nazi-Soviet Pact and the outbreak of WWII
 - Blitzkrieg and propaganda of invincibility
- **Module 11: Holocaust and the Nazi Empire (1941–1945):** (4 Hours) Topics:
 - The Wannsee Conference and “Final Solution”
 - Concentration camps, racial extermination, and genocide
 - War economy and the collapse of the Nazi state
 - Resistance movements and internal opposition
 - Cultural responses to the Holocaust
- **Module 12: The Collapse of the Nazi Regime (1944–1945):** (3 Hours) Topics:
 - Hitler’s fall and Allied occupation
 - Nuremberg Trials and denazification
 - Distinct post-war trajectories: East Germany, West Germany, Austria
 - The burden of memory and guilt in post-war literature and culture
- **Module 13: Legacy of the Weimar Republic and National Socialism:** (2 Hours) Topics:
 - The legacy of the Weimar Republic in post-war Germany
 - The division of Germany and the Cold War
 - The Nuremberg Trials and the denazification process
 - The moral and historical reckoning of National Socialism in post-war Europe

Text Books

1. Evans, Richard J. *The Coming of the Third Reich*. New York: Penguin Press, 2003.
2. Peukert, Detlev J. K. *The Weimar Republic: The Crisis of Classical Modernity*. Translated by Richard Deveson, Hill and Wang, 1992.

References

1. Beevor, Antony. *Berlin: The Downfall 1945*. Viking, 2002.
2. Bessel, Richard. *Germany After the First World War*. Oxford University Press, 1993.
3. Browning, Christopher R. *Ordinary Men: Reserve Police Battalion 101 and the Final Solution in Poland*. Harper Perennial, 1998.
4. Evans, Richard J. *The Coming of the Third Reich*. Penguin Press, 2003.
5. Friedländer, Saul. *Nazi Germany and the Jews, Volume 1: The Years of Persecution, 1933–1939*. HarperCollins, 1997.
6. Fulbrook, Mary. *German National Identity After the Holocaust*. Polity Press, 1999.
7. Fulda, Bernhard. “Press and Politics in the Weimar Republic.” *The English Historical Review*, vol. 125, no. 516, 2010, pp. 1276–1278.
8. Gay, Peter. *Weimar Culture: The Outsider as Insider*. W. W. Norton, 2001.
9. Herf, Jeffrey. *Divided Memory: The Nazi Past in the Two Germanys*. Harvard University Press, 1997.
10. Kershaw, Ian. *Hitler: Hubris, 1889–1936*. Penguin, 1998.
11. Kershaw, Ian. *The “Hitler Myth”: Image and Reality in the Third Reich*. Oxford University Press, 2001.
12. Mommsen, Hans. *The Rise and Fall of Weimar Democracy*. Translated by Elborg Forster and Larry Eugene Jones, University of North Carolina Press, 1996.
13. Overy, Richard. *The Dictators: Hitler’s Germany and Stalin’s Russia*. W. W. Norton, 2004.
14. Peukert, Detlev J. K. *The Weimar Republic: The Crisis of Classical Modernity*. Translated by Richard Deveson, Hill and Wang, 1992.
15. Stackelberg, Roderick. *Hitler’s Germany: Origins, Interpretations, Legacies*. Routledge, 2008.
16. Tooze, Adam. *The Wages of Destruction: The Making and Breaking of the Nazi Economy*. Viking, 2006.
17. Welch, David. *The Third Reich: Politics and Propaganda*. Routledge, 2002.